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Nahum

Nahum 1:1–8

God gave the prophet Nahum a vision.

The first part of it was about who God is. Nahum described God as jealous and angry. God is jealous when his people trust in anyone or anything but him to save them. God is angry when people do evil things. God is patient and doesn't take action on his anger quickly. This allows people the chance to turn away from their sin and to repent. If they refuse to change their ways, God brings judgement against them.

All of these things are true for each person and also for each group of people. When God took action on his anger, he marched out with storms and fire. That is what God's action looked like to Nahum in the vision. Nahum described God's power over creation. This showed that God has power over everything that exists. This includes human beings.

Nahum also described God as good. People should trust only in him for safety and salvation. God takes care of people who ask him for help when they are in trouble.

Nahum 1:9–3:19

Nahum spoke messages of judgement against Nineveh and Assyria.

The story about Jonah also included a message of judgement against Nineveh. That was many years before Nahum's time. At that time Jonah spoke God's message to the people and leaders of Nineveh. The Ninevites listened and changed their ways. They stopped doing evil things. God had mercy on them and didn't bring the judgement he had warned them about.

But during Nahum's time the people of Nineveh and Assyria were once again doing evil. The message that Nahum brought was different from Jonah's message. It wasn't only a warning to the city of Nineveh. It was an order from God about the entire nation of Assyria. The Assyrian government would have no more power. God had used the Assyrian government and armies as his tools to bring judgement.

They brought his judgement against the northern kingdom by taking complete control of it. They brought his judgement against the southern kingdom by causing much harm. God didn't allow Assyria to take complete control of the southern kingdom. But the southern kingdom was forced to support the Assyrian government with taxes. The story about this is recorded in 2 Kings chapters 18 and 19.

Yet the Assyrians didn't recognise that they had success because God gave it to them. They worshipped false gods and made evil plans against the Lord. They told lies, stole, murdered and practiced magic. They traded and did business in ways that ruined people groups and the land. These ways of living were completely against the way God wants people to live.

Because of this God would no longer use the Assyrians as his tool. The king, leaders, army and traders would be killed. Nahum spoke his messages about Assyria to the people of the southern kingdom. They were only one of the people groups that suffered because of Assyria. When God stopped the evil actions of the Assyrian government, it was good news. It was good news for people that the Assyrian government treated badly. Their suffering was over and they could have peace for a period of time.